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I must mention the way Dubai has transformed and led the way for tourism in the Middle East. It started with small areas of beach hotels, followed by a realisation that they need to do more. But 60% of their coastline is taken by the port and that led them to extend the coastline as much as possible. They then tried to do retail, or shopping tourism, with the biggest mall in the world and then the second-biggest mall in the world. A lot of fashion is based in Europe, and you've got to import that to Dubai.

Soon after, Dubai looked at its own natural assets to go beyond being just a shopping destination. Then, it started promoting outdoor adventure. Plus, it built a big convention centre and that gave it a way to do more events. Dubai is also an attractive destination for Indian weddings. That is a big market today. There is a lot to be learnt from what Dubai has done over time: when something did not work, it quickly thought of a new idea. The key was diversity. Today you find a bit of Vegas in Dubai or a bit of Miami or a bit of Singapore.

I think the focus on creating high quality airport

infrastructure [through Emirates] also helped Dubai in terms of ensuring connectivity across the world. That diversity is bringing in different segments of the market. When they focused only on one segment, they realised it's just not enough, it's too seasonal.

Q: What do you have to say about Indians going abroad for vacations? How are you going to convince Indians to spend more time here and spend more money in the hotel?

A: Our data shows that the domestic market is the largest and accounts for about 70% tourists. There are perhaps 200 million Indians who are high-end customers and can afford to travel outside. But there is a very large base wanting to travel across the country for spiritual tourism, staycations or business. **The hotels that we are building and the brands we are bringing in are more focused on the domestic market. Across the world, the domestic market is huge, be it Egypt, Saudi Arabia, India or China. BT**

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